LIFE ON BOARD

FOOD AND DRINK

AN AGE-OLD PROBLEM of naval warfare is how to keep ships supplied with food and drink at sea. In the ancient world galleys carried only enough supplies for a few days of sailing. Hugging the coastlines, they beached to buy food and usually ate on shore, although when the galley was in a hurry the oarsmen might snack while they rowed. As sailing ships ventured far from land, however, they had to carry their own supplies with them for long periods of time. This led to health problems because of the lack of fresh food available and inadequate methods of food preservation.

STORAGE Provisions in the hold of a reconstructed Spanish royal galley from 1570. Typical daily fare issued to the oarsmen would have included a 26 oz (720 g) biscuit, made by baking bread and legumes without oil. Pork and wine was added to the volunteers' rations.



A SAILOR'S DIET

Sailors basically consumed the food and drink typical of their society. In the 16th century Spanish sailors ate squid, tuna, sardines, oil, rice, and wine, while the English ships carried beef, butter, and beer. The distinguishing feature of shipboard food was that it needed to last. So freshly baked bread was replaced by biscuit, provided for Venetian galley crews as "biscotti" and the Royal Navy as "hard tack." Although liable to infestation by weevils and other pests, it provided a good basic foodstuff. Salted meat and fish ("stockfish") were also near universal staples, along with cheese and peas or lentils. That these lacked essential vitamins found in fresh food was recognized long before any scientific explanation was available. Navies in the 18th century tried to provide fresh fruit and vegetables when possible and carried live animals for slaughter. Sailors were on the whole not badly fed by the standards of their day. Scurvy, a disease formed by a deficiency of vitamin C, was found on land as well as at sea.

> *The crew made haste that they (did not stop for meals but) pulled and ate at the same time, barley bread mixed with wine and olive oil.*
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> **THUCYDIDES** (c.400 BCE), on the exceptional circumstances when a trireme crew did not go ashore to take their meal.



FRESH FOOD Live animals were brought on board when space permitted in order to overcome the problem of meat spoiling in storage. This meant that men and livestock shared the confines of the lower gun deck, lending additional odor and noise to already overcrowded conditions.

COOKING AND MESSING

Arrangements for messing (eating) and cooking on a packed wooden sailing ship were always unsatisfactory. Men messed on the gun deck where they slept, letting down tables that hung from the deckhead. There were typically eight men to a mess. One man from each mess prepared the rations and brought them to the ship's cook—a petty officer, often a disabled man unfit for other service. For safety reasons the cooking fire was small and in the safest place that could be found. All food was typically cooked in a single large pot. Until the mid-19th century men provided their own table utensils. Naturally, life for officers was very different and quite luxurious by comparison. They could pay for their own more refined food and drink, and were waited on by servants, sometimes eating from silver plates.



CLOSE QUARTERS The crew on a 19th-century warship would have eaten elbow to elbow amid guns and hammocks. Eight adults and one boy would have sat around this table.



HARD TACK "Ship's biscuits" were so hard that sailors would dunk them in liquid to soften them up.



BEER TANKARD Beer was standard in Nelson's navy since water soon went stagnant in the storage barrels.